

WASTE MANAGEMENT IN CAMEROON

Introduction

Waste management refers to the collection, transportation, treatment, recycling, and disposal of waste in a safe and proper way. Waste can be solid, liquid, or gaseous, and it comes from homes, industries, hospitals, markets, and agricultural activities.

In Cameroon, rapid urbanization, population growth, and industrial development have increased the amount of waste produced every day. Cities such as Yaoundé and Douala face major waste management problems because of poor infrastructure, inadequate funding, and limited public awareness. Proper waste management is important because it helps to protect human health, preserve the environment, reduce pollution, and improve living conditions.

Major Problems of Waste Management in Cameroon

a) Poor Collection of Waste:

Many neighborhoods do not receive regular waste collection services. As a result, waste accumulates in streets and drainage systems. That is, Waste collection trucks are insufficient, Some roads are inaccessible, and rural areas receive little attention.

b) Lack of Public Awareness:

Many people dispose of waste carelessly because they do not understand the dangers of improper waste disposal. For instance, people throw plastics into rivers and gutters, and open dumping is common, and environmental education is limited.

c) Inadequate Recycling Facilities:

Cameroon has very few recycling centers.

Most waste is dumped instead of recycled, valuable materials like plastics and metals are wasted, and recycling industries are underdeveloped.

d) Poor Government Funding:

Waste management requires large financial resources. Local councils often lack funds, equipment and machines are old or insufficient, workers are poorly equipped and unskilled.

e) Rapid Urbanization:

Cities are growing faster than waste management systems. Population increase leads to more waste production. Informal settlements lack proper sanitation. Urban planning is weak.

Effects of Poor Waste Management

a) Environmental Pollution

Improper disposal of waste pollutes land, air, and water, and can cause harm to the population. For instance, plastics also block drainage systems, waste dumped into rivers contaminates water, and burning waste releases harmful gases.

b) Health Problems:

Poor waste disposal can spread diseases. Mosquitoes breed in stagnant water. Flies spread germs. Diseases such as cholera and typhoid increase.

c) Bad Odor and Poor Living Conditions:

Accumulated waste creates unpleasant smells and dirty surroundings which communities become unhealthy, causing tourism to decrease, and Quality of life is reduced.

d) Climate Change:

Burning waste and decomposition release greenhouse gases, such as Methane and carbon dioxide contribute to global warming, and Air quality becomes poor.

Solutions to Waste Management Problems**a) Public Education and Awareness:**

The population should be educated on proper waste disposal, Schools can teach environmental education. And Media campaigns can inform citizens. Also, communities should organize sanitation exercises.

b) Recycling and Reuse:

Waste materials should be recycled and reused. For instance, plastics can be transformed into new products, organic waste can be used for compost and recycling also creates employment opportunities.

c) Government Support and Policies:

The government should strengthen the waste management company by increasing funding for waste management, providing more waste bins and trucks and punishing illegal dumping.

d) Community Participation:

Communities should participate actively in keeping their environment clean by doing monthly clean-up campaigns that can encourage proper waste separation, and promote responsibility among citizens.

e) Private Sector Involvement:

Private companies can assist in waste collection and recycling ,Partnership with councils improves efficiency. Companies can invest in recycling plants, and new jobs can be created.

Conclusion

Waste management is a major challenge in Cameroon due to poor infrastructure, weak public awareness, inadequate funding, and rapid urbanization. Poor waste management causes pollution, diseases, flooding, and environmental degradation.

However, the problem can be reduced through public education, recycling, government intervention, community participation, and better waste collection systems. Proper waste management is necessary for sustainable development and for improving the health and well-being of the population.